different tables in small groups. The loners were at it by themselves. And then the ground shook. The noise from the explosion took out much of the windows. We heard screams and then pandemonium followed. Most people took cover under the tables or leapt into the kitchen area or the lobby on the far side.

I took a different approach. I exited the building and went out into the street, the PIDC Chowk, one of the busiest intersections of the city. I knew the area well. For years I had dropped by that spot for a late-night paan (and maybe a quick smoke to go with my betel leaf treat, though I'm not a regular smoker). It's a place where paan lovers from different parts of the city – the 'burgers' from Defence, the '*laundas*' from Gulshan, the '*mailas*' from Clifton – would congregate late in the night to enjoy the best '*saada khushboo*' or '*tambaqoo wala*' or the go-to '*meetha*' in the city.

But that day, even before I could get to the street, I could smell the charred body parts of those killed and injured in the blast. I don't like to recall the exact details of what I saw, but I remember going to the policemen who had arrived on the scene and helping them out in clearing the area. Everybody was in shock and responding in their own ways. My response was to try and make sense of the surroundings and help restore whatever order that could be at the site of the bombing. I offered the cops water to drink and then departed from there once the ambulances arrived, so that the medics could do their job. It must not have been easy.

Later, I went to check up on our guests, the New Zealand team. They were scared and shaken up – we all were – and had assembled at the poolside, a safer spot since it was tucked inside a concrete enclave of the hotel. The Kiwis all flew back home soon after. What a terrible day for Pakistan, for the French (who were targeted) and for the game of cricket. As war and terror, and the war on terror, went global, it seemed that morning in Karachi that the cricket world was spiralling down too.

By 2002, the Pakistan team peaked again, and we overcame our World Cup final blues by beating Australia in a remarkably fought ODI series Down Under. There were a few of us young guns – Imran Nazir, Saqlain and I – in that team, but there were a few seniors who were hitting their own political snags as the year progressed. All that compounded into a far-from-ideal scenario in South Africa in 2003, where, under Waqar Younis's captaincy, we crashed out of the World Cup at the end of the group games stage itself. We didn't win anything of consequence. We lost our opening game against Australia, a match where we'd hoped to undo the loss at the 1999 World Cup final. But nothing special happened. Shoaib couldn't keep his mouth shut about Brett Lee. Nor could I for that matter – I was banned by the PCB for sledging against India (more on that in just a bit). Moreover, something had gone awfully wrong with our team's leadership. We were down, and then we were out.

Team sports can get complicated. But in order to function, every team must start with a basic tenet: a unit needs unity. And the Pakistan team didn't have much of it. There was a change in the chain of command and Waqar, the new man at the helm, was, unfortunately, a terrible captain. He couldn't hold us together. He couldn't fight off the politics inside the dressing room. I think he himself was responsible for much of it. There was a lot of ill will within the team at the time. It was a bad, bad time to be in the Pakistan side.

As usual, the press got it all wrong and made the divisions worse. There were reports about infighting within the team. An example that's often cited to substantiate such reports is the